

Something's been bothering you and you haven't said it yet

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

Bring it up as one specific moment rather than the whole pattern, and it usually goes better than the version you've been running in your head. Most people get a milder reaction than they braced for.

THE GOAL

You're saying the one thing today, before the waiting costs you more than the conversation would. Pick a moment when you're alone together and nobody is about to interrupt.

CHECKLIST

You've decided this is the day, and you're about to bring it up with them.

- ☐ If you're wound up, do something that takes full attention, like a quick task or a short walk, instead of rehearsing what to say.
- ☐ Find a moment when you're alone together and not about to be interrupted or rushed.
- ☐ Say what happened in one plain sentence, the specific moment, not the whole pattern.
- ☐ Once you've said it, pause there. Wait for them to speak before you continue.
- ☐ Name how they're responding: getting defensive, brushing it off, or actually taking it in.
- ☐ If they get defensive, repeat the specific moment you named, calmly, instead of matching their tone.
- ☐ If they brush it off, say plainly why it matters to you.
- ☐ If they're taking it in, ask what their side of it is before you respond.
- ☐ If it turns into raised voices or you're going in circles, say you want to pause and come back to it later.
- ☐ Say what you'd like to be different, not only what was wrong.
- ☐ If they offer something, repeat it back in your own words so you both heard the same thing.
- ☐ If it isn't settled in this sitting, agree on when you'll pick it back up.
- ☐ Write down what was said or agreed, somewhere you'll find it, in case it comes up again.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Hiding how you really feel during a conversation already costs you closeness with them.
- 2 You're bracing for a **harsher reaction** than you're likely to get. People about to raise a real problem consistently predict more anger and a worse response than the other person ends up actually having.
- 3 Waiting this long doesn't mean something is wrong with you. In one poll of employees, a quarter had waited six months to have a conversation they knew they needed to have, and one in ten had waited more than two years.

What waiting is costing you

DON'T

Hiding how you really feel during a conversation already costs you closeness with them.

Partners of someone hiding their reaction during a conversation reported feeling less close and connected to them, without being told why. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

Waiting doesn't make a hard moment easier. Dread grows early on, and only slows down later.

People waiting for a moderately painful moment they couldn't avoid found the dread grew the longer the wait went on. [Source 3](#)

DON'T

Replaying what angered you while venting physically, like hitting something, doesn't cool you off. It leaves you angrier than distracting yourself the same way, and both angrier and more aggressive than not venting at all.

People who replayed anger while venting stayed angrier than people who were distracted, and more aggressive than people who didn't vent at all. [Source 1](#)

What you're bracing for

KNOW

You're bracing for a **harsher reaction** than you're likely to get. People about to raise a real problem consistently predict more anger and a worse response than the other person ends up actually having.

People confronting a roommate or partner about a real problem predicted more anger than they actually got. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Your face probably gives away less than you think. People hiding a reaction think more people notice than really do.

Tasters hiding their reaction to a foul drink guessed almost five out of 10 observers would notice, when only about three and a half did. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Waiting this long doesn't mean something is wrong with you. In one poll of employees, a quarter had waited six months to have a conversation they knew they needed to have, and one in ten had waited more than two years.

The same poll found **more than 80%** of people were avoiding a conversation like this at work too. [Source 7](#)

What lands when you say it

SAY

Name the specific thing that happened, not their character. In newlywed couples who later divorced, it was usually the wife's opening that turned into a character attack instead.

In newlywed couples who later divorced, the wife usually opened with a character attack instead of the specific thing that happened. [Source 6](#)

DO

Say it, then stop and let them respond before you say more. People who had a real back-and-forth ended up less angry and learned things a one-way speech never surfaces.

People who had a real back-and-forth also said the other person **engaged with them more**, alongside feeling less angry themselves. [Source 2](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Hitting a pillow or punching bag to let your anger out will help you go into the conversation calmer.

ACTUALLY

It does the opposite. People who vented anger this way, hitting a bag while thinking about who'd angered them, ended up angrier and more aggressive than people who **did nothing at all**. [Source 1](#)

Sources

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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Difficult conversations at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)